Kidneys and Commitments

By Gil Reyes

(Pg 301-305) I'm sure the woman on the other end of the phone identified herself as being from the clinic I'd been to the day before. Maybe she said her name. Maybe she asked if I was sitting down. But I don't remember any of that. In my memory I just pick up the phone, and this voice says, "Go immediately to the emergency room. Your kidneys are failing."

And as I get up and get dressed, there's this voice in the back of my head saying, ***This is absurd. I'm in my twenties. I'm invincible. I'm immortal. I don't even need health insurance.*** . . I don't even ***have*** health insurance.

INTRODUCTION

Let's talk statistics for a minute. According to Donate Life America, currently more than 90,000 people are on the national kidney transplant waiting list. Every 10 minutes, another person is added. That means these seriously ill individuals are . . .

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1. *Waiting for person with a healthy kidney to die*
2. *Hoping the deceased has agreed in advance to donate their organs*
3. *Praying that the organ is a biological match*
4. *Undergoing costly dialysis 3 times a week;4 hours a day just to stay alive.*

But even though the process of live donor transplants was widely accepted in the 1950s . . . in 2021, 6,000 people in the US died while on the waiting list. If you want to become a living donor, contact a transplant center near you for an initial evaluation. You can save a life.

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Sure, I'd been feeling bad for a while. But my swollen ankles, those were because I was waiting tables, working double shifts, trying to save up money, not because my body wasn't processing water waste, right? And those splitting headaches, those were because I was really stressed out, trying to get into grad schools, and not because your kidneys regulate your blood pressure.

When I had finally collapsed a few days before, I didn't have any more excuses. That was when my boyfriend, Sean, made me go to the clinic. Sean and I had been dating for a year and living together for a few

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months. It was moving a little bit fast, but either of us could go to grad school at any minute, so it was fine. We had sort of a day-by-day mentality. We were keeping each other just at arm's length.

In fact, I was able to convince him not to go with me to the emergency room. I mean, why should we both sit around all day waiting for some doctors to tell me that that's not what it is? That it's something else-something that can be fixed with a pill?

So, I went. Alone. Terrified, but hiding it well. And this trait of mine, this sort of crazy independence, maybe it stems from when I came out to my Southern Baptist mother from Alabama and my Catholic Hispanic dad from Texas, when I was a teenager growing up in Kentucky. If you're thinking this didn't go well, you're right . . . There were Bibles manifesting from nowhere (even though I'd been to church more than they had throughout my life). There was screaming and yelling, and I left that night thinking, ***I'm one of the damned***. Because they told me, "You're going to hell."

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We didn't speak for a while-over a year. And when we began to try to put our relationship back together, the damage was pretty done. How close can you get when there's this whole part of your life that somebody wants nothing to do with? I remember once, out of the blue, my dad, said, "I never want to meet anyone you're seeing. I don't ever want you to bring anybody home."

But as my emergency-room visit became a ten-day stay in the hospital, I had to let a lot of people know where I was. In fact, that hospital room was where my parents first met Sean. I learned my kidneys were functioning at less than 10 percent. I learned that I would probably have to go on dialysis.

If you don't know much about dialysis, it's a way to live. It's not a *great* way to live. It's not pleasant. It's very time-consuming. It's expensive. No, what you want in this situation is a living donor, a kidney donor. You could get on the national transplant list. That is going to take time, maybe years, waiting with a bag packed by the door. And cadaver kidneys have other

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issues; they're not the best choice. If you can get a living donor, though, usually family-somebody who's a perfect match-that's the ideal situation.

Well, my relationship with my parents had left me a little bit wounded. I had trouble trusting people. This is one of the things I was bad at in my twenties. It used to be at the top of the list. Now the top of the list was kidney function. But the not trusting people was still up there. I had this trouble with accepting help. And if you have trouble accepting help, imagine trying to accept a kidney.

People stepped up to get tested. My dad, despite our differences. My mother wasn't eligible. My best friend, his dad. Friends from college, high school, work. But there was one more person who really wanted to get tested: Sean. Talk about a commitment. He eventually wore me down.

He said, "You know, whatever happens, whether or not we're together in the future-if I can do this for you now, I want to."

As the months began to pass, and I did go on

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dialysis, and my father was disqualified as a donor because of kidney stones, I went on Social Security and food stamps because I was too weak to work. Friends were disqualified for various reasons.

I wasn't going to be going to grad school. I spent a lot of time thinking about how I was going from twenty to eighty overnight. Comparing blood-pressure medicines with my grandmother. I spent a lot of time alone, sleeping, mostly. But I remember this one day where I made it out to the park, and I was sitting alone. It was a cool day, a fall day. I was praying, meditating, considering this entire process. And I found this really strange peace that's hard to describe.

I found this kind of acceptance of myself, and where I'd been, and I thought, ***You know, it's fine. If this is what it is, if this is it, I'm okay with that. I can die in my twenties.*** I stopped praying to get better, and I thought about the thing that I'd want. If I could pray for one thing, it was to feel worthy of that love that I hadn't felt for so long. I stopped asking for time, and thought about time *well spent.*

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It was December when Sean called me from work and said, "I have an early Christmas present for you." He was as good a match as my dad. He said, "Would you let me give you a kidney?" And I said, "Yes." And we spent time well. Sean's a big language geek, so we named it: Renee, after the renal system, and Renatus, for rebirth.

We would tell people, "We're having a kidney!" Our friends convinced us to have a party. We had a kidney shower. (Sean really wanted to register, but I thought that might be going a little far.) Nevertheless, people brought us gifts: pajamas for recovering, and bad movies. (Sean ***loves*** bad movies.) And we played games, like "kidney bean bingo" and "pin the kidney on Gil." We got this big red-velvet sheet cake shaped like a kidney. And we wore medical masks, and we cut it together, and fed each other pieces and took lots of pictures.

The day of the surgery came in May, and they had us both on gurneys, ready to go. We're surrounded by Sean's family and my family. My parents are there. And

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my mother starts crying. We never talk about this, but we cry the same way. We scrunch up our cheeks in the same way, and we hold back those tears. I can see it in her face when she's trying to work something out.

She leans down and takes Sean's hand and says, "Thank you." I think she's seeing him differently, and maybe she's seeing me differently.

The surgery goes great, and we recovered together for weeks and weeks in a strange little honeymoon . . . A year later we get a card in the mail. Now, it's not unusual for my mother to send cards. (She sends cards for the strangest occasions, even though they live fifteen minutes away.) But this one was addressed to Sean. It said what a blessing he is. And it recognized our anniversary. They asked us to go to dinner with them, like couples do with their parents.

And I never asked for any proof, because you're supposed to rely on faith, but I have a family where I have parents and a partner-a perfect match-where before I had a boyfriend. And a ten-inch scar across my abdomen to remind me every day that I am loved.

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